

I discovered the power of gratitude while I was in the thick of repaying my debt, and trying to find a way to make peace with money as I was learning to understand and control it. With most of our income going on bills and debt repayments, there was a lot of lifestyle adjusting to be done, and it was sometimes difficult not to feel resentful of the things that I felt I was missing out on. I needed to find a way to reframe the experience I was having, and gratitude gave me the ability to do that.

There are a number of studies investigating the science of gratitude and how it helps to improve mental health,⁴ but it can actually be quite difficult to define what gratitude is. Here, we're talking about it as a practice – something that we actively participate in – but for most of us, gratitude is a feeling that occurs naturally under certain conditions. Psychologists Dr Robert Emmons and Dr Michael McCullough define gratitude as a two-step process: 1) 'recognizing that one has obtained a positive outcome' and 2) 'recognizing that there is an external source for this positive outcome.'⁵ In my experience, both of these things require active recognition if we're to fully appreciate them, rather than relying on an innate sense of gratitude that must compete with other, louder thoughts and feelings in order for us to hear and acknowledge it. And, while it does seem that some people are naturally more able to tune into that grateful inner voice than others, the good news is that it's possible to train ourselves to listen more closely, and that the act of amplifying our gratitude could help to diminish those